

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

1 Thessalonians

1 Thessalonians

As new Christians, the believers in Thessalonica did not yet fully understand their faith. They also suffered strong opposition. Could these new believers stay faithful in this hard social setting?

First Thessalonians teaches that faithful leaders, clear teaching, and obedience help believers stay strong in their faith. The letter also shows that God is powerfully at work in the lives of those he has called through the good news of Jesus Christ.

Setting

Thessalonica was an important city in Macedonia. It had a good relationship with Rome and with Roman citizens who lived there. The city did not have to pay Roman taxes. It could make its own coins. It also did not have to keep Roman soldiers inside the city walls. Thessalonica became rich and powerful as a center for government and trade. Its influence reached across Macedonia and into other areas.

Thessalonica had a mixed population. It included Macedonians, Romans, Jews, and other people who traveled through the city. Many Romans who settled there became rich and supported public life in the city. The Jewish community was large enough to have a synagogue, a place where Jews met for worship and teaching (Acts 17:1).

Luke describes how the good news came to Thessalonica in Acts 17:1–9. When Paul preached in the synagogue, some Jews believed in Christ. Most of the believers in Thessalonica, however, were non-Jews (Gentiles). They had worshiped idols, but they stopped worshiping false gods to follow Christ (1 Thessalonians 1:9).

The Jews who did not accept the good news started a riot against the apostles. They accused Paul and Silas of causing trouble in the city (Acts 17:4–7). They made this charge to turn people against Paul and Silas. The Romans did not tolerate social unrest, or public disorder. Because of this, Paul and his companions had to leave the city after only a short time.

Paul left behind a church that was still very young in the faith. The believers were already suffering persecution, or harm because of their faith (1 Thessalonians 1:6; 2:14; 3:3–4). They had not yet received all the teaching they needed. They also did not have mature leaders to guide the church.

Paul then traveled to Berea, Athens, and finally Corinth (Acts 17:10–18:1). As he traveled, he was deeply concerned about the believers in Thessalonica. He tried more than once to return to the city. But serious problems stopped him, and he understood these problems as the work of Satan (1 Thessalonians 2:17–18).

While Paul was in Athens, he could no longer bear his concern for the church. He sent Timothy back to Thessalonica to strengthen the believers. He also wanted to make sure they had not abandoned their faith (3:1–2, 5). Later, while Paul was in Corinth, Timothy returned from Thessalonica. He brought the good news that the believers were still living in faith and love. They were standing firm even though they faced opposition (3:6–8).

First Thessalonians shows Paul's great joy when he heard this report. In the letter, Paul thanks God for their faithfulness. He also prays that he may return to see them again and help them grow stronger in the faith (3:9–11).

Summary

First Thessalonians is a letter full of thanks to God. Paul thanks God for the faith, love, and hope of the young church in Thessalonica (1 Thessalonians 1:2–3; 2:13; 3:9). Paul also shares some of his concerns. In the ancient world, many traveling speakers wanted only money and fame. In 2:1–3:13, Paul explains his motives and ministry. He did not come to Thessalonica to seek praise or wealth. He truly cared for the believers there.

Paul wanted to see the church again. He had tried to return, but he had not been able to do so (2:17–20). Paul also reminds them that he had sent Timothy back to strengthen them and to learn how they were doing (3:1–5). Timothy later brought Paul a good report. This report greatly comforted Paul (3:6–8). Paul then tells the church that he thanks God for them. He also prays that he may see them again and help them grow stronger in the faith (3:9–13).

Some people in the church did not follow Paul's teaching about sexual purity. In response, Paul teaches that God wants them to be holy, or set apart for him (4:1–8). Other people in the church refused to work. They did not follow the teaching and example of the apostles about this matter (4:11–12; 5:14; see 2 Thessalonians 3:6–15).

The Thessalonians also had questions for Paul:

1. What happens to believers who die before Christ returns? Paul says they will be raised from the dead first. Then they will be gathered with the living

believers to meet the Lord when he appears (1 Thessalonians 4:13–18).

2. When will Christ return and complete God's final plan? Paul says that day will come at an unexpected time, like a thief in the night (5:1–11). So they should be ready by living with faith, love, and hope.

The letter ends with several instructions about how to live in a way that pleases God. Paul reminds the church to honor its new leaders (5:12–13). Paul also tells the Thessalonians not to reject prophecies, or messages that claim to come from God. Instead, they should test them carefully (5:19–22). The letter ends with a blessing. This blessing shows Paul's complete trust that God is faithful and will continue to work in their lives (5:23–24).

Author

Silas and Timothy helped Paul start the church in Thessalonica. Their names appear with Paul's name at the beginning of the letter (1:1). Most of the letter uses the word *we*. This may mean that Silas and Timothy helped write the letter. Paul sometimes speaks for himself when he shares his own concerns (2:18; 3:5; 5:27).

In the ancient world, more than one person could help write a letter. For example, Cicero, a Roman writer, mentions "letters—both that which you wrote with others and the one you wrote alone." Even so, the final command in 5:27 suggests that Paul had the main role in writing the letter. Silas and Timothy may have helped, but Paul seems to have guided the letter most directly.

Date and Occasion of Writing

Paul wrote this letter from Corinth during his second missionary journey (Acts 15:36–18:22). He wrote it after Timothy returned from visiting the church in Thessalonica (1 Thessalonians 3:6; Acts 18:5). Gallio became proconsul, or Roman governor, of Achaia in AD 51. This happened while Paul was staying in Corinth (Acts 18:11–12). For this reason, Paul probably wrote First Thessalonians near the end of AD 50.

First Thessalonians is one of Paul's earliest letters. Only Galatians was probably written earlier.

Meaning and Message

First Thessalonians shows the life and struggles of a new church. These new believers faced many challenges because Paul and the other church founders were with them for only a short time. The believers were suffering strong opposition from their own people because of their faith (1 Thessalonians 1:6; 2:14;

3:3–4). Paul believed Satan, the tempter, was attacking them (3:5). Paul also believed Satan had stopped him from visiting them again (2:18).

When Timothy returned from visiting them, Paul was very glad. He learned that the Thessalonians were living like people who truly belonged to Christ. Their lives showed faith, love, and hope (1:3; 3:6; 5:8). They also helped spread the good news in the nearby regions (1:8). They became examples of true faith for other believers, even while they were suffering (1:6–7).

What helped the Thessalonians stay strong in faith during great suffering? Some people might say they stayed faithful because of strong personal choice, good training, or "blind faith," which means belief without clear reason. But Paul says that God chose the believers (1:4). He also says that the good news about Jesus is God's own message and shows God's power (1:5).

When people receive this message, it continues to work powerfully in them (2:13). True conversion means turning away from sin and idols and turning to the true God. It also means serving God while waiting for his Son to return from heaven (1:9–10).

The Christians in Thessalonica were young in the faith. They were separated from the people who started their church. They also suffered because they had trusted in Christ. Even so, God was at work in them. Their strong faith was the work of Christ (3:8, 13).

Still, these new Christians needed to grow in right living and in their understanding of God's truth. Paul had warned the Thessalonians about sexual immorality, or wrong sexual behavior. But some people rejected his teaching (4:3–8). They also did not understand how Christ's resurrection gave them hope when other believers died. Christ's resurrection means that God raised Jesus from the dead (4:13–18).

They were confused about when Christ would return (5:1–11). Some people in the church did not follow Paul's teaching about work (4:11; 5:14). Others did not show proper respect to the new leaders in the church (5:12–13). Finally, some Thessalonians were stopping prophecy in the church (5:19–22).

Correction may feel unpleasant, but we need it to grow in right living and in our understanding of God's truth. Paul writes this letter as a wise pastor. He wants to help the Thessalonian believers with these problems. Paul hopes the letter will guide them until he can return to them (3:10). In the end, every leader should trust God to keep working in believers' lives (5:23). God is faithful and will do this (5:24).